announced in 2010, 'A new global economic geography is born'. However, relying upon financiers such as Goldman Sachs' Jim O'Neill (originator of the 'BRIC' meme in 2001) to codify economic power is risky. What appeared as a strong bloc of BRICS countries at a leadership summit in March 2013 became, within four months, the core of the 'Fragile Five' countries, leaving O'Neill to remark that only China deserved the 'building-block' BRICS designation (Magalhaes 2013). Meanwhile, India, South Africa and Brazil lost vast amounts of their currency values and funding flows once financial capital left these markets in search of the dollar safe-haven once the US Federal Reserve's loose monetary policy – 'Quantitative Easing' – began to be 'tapered' in mid-2013. The same experience of massive capital outflow hit Russia in early 2014, first because of the loss of regional power signified by the Ukraine's government overthrow, and then when Moscow began a blunt takeover of Crimea, the threat of Western sanctions crashed its stock market. The rot continued in 2015, and the prospect of the end of China's economic miracle also loomed.

So notwithstanding the validity of the general approach Luxemburg proposed, in which ongoing capital accumulation entails imperialism reaching into the terrain of extra-economic coercion, this is not a stable outcome. Each situation must be evaluated on its own concrete terms. Dating at least a half-century to when the idea of sub-imperialism was introduced, in Brazil, the concrete settings are vital because contingencies arise that may divert from the twin logics of capital and expanding territorial power relations.

Concrete sub-imperial locations

The new concentrations of Southern power began to be evident by the 1960s when new alliances strengthened in the Cold War context. In his pioneering writing about Latin American geopolitics dating to the 1960s, Marini (1974) argued that 1970s-era Brazil was 'the best current manifestation of sub-imperialism', because of regional economic extraction, export of capital typically associated with imperialist politics, and internal corporate monopolisation, including financialisation.

There are three additional roles for these regimes today, if they are to be considered sub-imperialist. One is ensuring regional geopolitical 'stability' in areas suffering severe tensions: for example, Brasilia's army in Haiti and Pretoria's deal-making in African hotspots like South Sudan, the Great Lakes and the Central African Republic (although in West Africa, especially Côte d'Ivoire, Pretoria was far less influential). The Israeli and Saudi Arabian roles in the Middle East are comparable, and white-ruled South Africa was, likewise, a Western